After the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991, a situation developed in which Russia needed Iranian support to prevent the infiltration of radical Islam into Russia and the Asian republics, and Iran needed Russian weapons and technology.

President Putin's policy since 2000 has aspired to restore Russia's former superpower status. Ideally this would be done with the consent of the United States, but if that is not possible, Russia will still continue to pursue this goal. Still, post-1991 Russia does not have the power to dictate to the United States, so the only strategy it can adopt to advance its goal is to use its "nuisance value." This is how Russia has turned into the "spoiler" trying to throw spokes in the wheels of any American international initiative.

Russian officials, both past and present, have spoken in closed circles about the humiliation the US administration has brought upon Russia since 1991. Since the demarcation of the Soviet Union's borders at the end of World War II, Russia had not shrunk in size to the extent it did after the Cold War and the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991. Russia lost all of eastern Europe and the Baltic states and is still trying to maintain some influence in Ukraine; first it seized the Crimean peninsula and annexed it, and later it took control of territory in eastern Ukraine. The conflict, as of late 2018, is still in full swing. In terms of conventional strategy, the western gateway to Moscow is no longer protected. Russia lost the Asian republics, an event that had far-reaching implications with regard to energy. It lost Georgia, which had "imported an American president from the United States," thereby exposing Russia's southern underbelly.

All Russian political, international, or strategic decisions are made on the basis of the extent to which the decision will bring Russia closer to being recognized once again as a global superpower. In 1992, I met with Yevgeny Primakov, then head of the KGB, in Moscow, at his invitation. At the end of a long and exhausting day of discussions, which were conducted through an interpreter, we shook hands and were about to part ways. Suddenly, Primakov switched over to fluent English and told me: "I want you to convey to your political masters in Israel that Russia was a superpower, Russia has the potential of a superpower, and Russia will again be a superpower."

On January 20, 2009, as President Obama entered the White House, I sent him a letter via an envoy. I recommended that the Obama